

Kant's Transcendental Idealism and Eternal Progression

On the Resemblance, and the Rupture, Between an Asymptotic and a Teleological Perfection

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ABSTRACT

Kant's transcendental idealism and the Latter-day Saint doctrine of eternal progression both refuse a single, instantaneous, static salvation, making perfection a trajectory rather than a state. This essay locates two joints where the resemblance genuinely holds — the asymptotic moral self of the second *Critique* and the uncreated self that grounds freedom — and three where it breaks: epistemic posture (a postulate held in moral faith versus a revealed metaphysic), asymptote versus arrival (an endless approach that never closes the gap versus a real deification that does), and the kind of God at the end of the process (a non-anthropomorphic moral postulate versus an embodied being continuous with humanity). The family resemblance is real; the traditions diverge less on whether perfection is a process than on how confidently one may say so, and on whether the gap between creature and God ever actually closes.

Keywords: *Kant · transcendental idealism · eternal progression · postulate · deification · moral faith*

I. The Resonance and the Thesis

It is tempting, and cheap, to hear in “eternal progression” only a rhyme with Kant's word *eternal* and stop there. The resonance is deeper than the pun, and more interesting, because it survives the removal of the shared vocabulary: both Kant and the Latter-day Saint tradition refuse the picture of salvation as a single, instantaneous, static event, and both put in its place a picture of perfection as a *trajectory* — something one is always on the way toward, never simply in possession of. The refusal is structural, and it is the same refusal. What follows from it is not.

This essay argues that the family resemblance is real and locatable — it holds at two identifiable joints and breaks at three — and that the interesting question is not whether the two traditions agree that perfection is a process (they do) but *how confidently each is permitted to say so*, and *whether the gap between the creature and God ever actually closes*. Kant gives

us an epistemically modest, asymptotic version of eternal progression: an endless approach, never an arrival, advanced with no claim to know it is true. The Latter-day Saint tradition gives us an epistemically confident, teleological one: an actual arrival, doctrinally asserted, with an ontological continuity between the human and the divine. Between those two lies the whole of the disagreement, and it is worth mapping precisely, because a resemblance stated loosely flatters both parties and instructs neither.

I proceed in three movements. The first locates where the two accounts genuinely rhyme — in the asymptotic structure of the moral self, and in the refusal to let that self be wholly constituted by an external cause. The second locates where they pull apart, along three axes that are, I will argue, at least as important as the resemblance. The third offers a compact framing of the whole, and asks what the comparison teaches about the price each tradition pays for the shape of perfection it chooses.

II. Where They Rhyme

The asymptotic self

The strongest connection lies in the second *Critique*. Kant argues that morality demands the complete conformity of the will with the moral law — holiness — a conformity no finite, embodied rational being can achieve at any single moment¹. The moral law commands this holiness unconditionally, without lowering its demand to what a creature can presently meet². From the gap between the command and the creature Kant draws not despair but a postulate: because the demand is unconditional and the achievement is impossible in a moment, practical reason requires an endless progress toward the perfect fitness of the will — and this endless progress in turn requires the immortality of the soul as its condition³. Perfection, for Kant, is not a state one snaps into but a trajectory one is set upon and continues indefinitely, approaching the standard asymptotically forever.

The structure is strikingly close to eternal progression, and it is worth noting that the scriptural traditions the Latter-day Saints inherit already speak in the same asymptotic register. The Sermon on the Mount issues the command to perfection as a *standard* — “be perfect, therefore, as your heavenly Father is perfect”⁴ — not as a report that perfection has been reached; and the prophetic idiom of growth “line upon line, precept upon precept”⁵ describes exactly the incremental, unfinished ascent Kant’s postulate formalizes. Where Kant reasons his way to endless moral progress from the structure of obligation, the tradition simply commands the ascent and describes its manner. The convergence is not on a doctrine but on a *shape*: perfection set as a standard toward which one is always advancing, never a possession one already holds.

The uncreated self

There is a second, deeper resonance, and it concerns the nature of the self. Kant’s transcendental idealism locates the real self — the free, noumenal self — outside the causal, spatiotemporal order altogether. Appearances are governed by natural necessity, but the self as it is in itself is

¹Immanuel Kant, *Critique of Practical Reason*, trans. Thomas Kingsmill Abbott (Public domain (Project Gutenberg), 1788), Ak. 5:122.

²Kant, *Critique of Practical Reason*, Ak. 5:32.

³Kant, *Critique of Practical Reason*, Ak. 5:122.

⁴*The Holy Bible: World English Bible* (Public domain, 2000), Matthew 5:48.

⁵*The Holy Bible: World English Bible*, Isaiah 28:10.

not merely one more link in that chain⁶; freedom is secured precisely because the self is not, at bottom, a product of nature⁷. The move is a refusal: the self that acts is not wholly constituted by the deterministic order that constitutes everything it can observe, and only that refusal makes genuine moral agency intelligible.

Latter-day Saint theology, following the King Follett discourse, makes a structurally parallel refusal. The core of personhood — what the discourse calls “intelligence” — is held to be uncreated and co-eternal with God, never having had a beginning and never having been made⁸. Both moves do the same philosophical work: they ground genuine moral agency by refusing to let the self be entirely constituted or determined by an external creator or a deterministic causal order. Kant secures freedom by placing the noumenal self beyond nature; the King Follett discourse secures it by placing the intelligence beyond creation. The metaphysical vocabularies could hardly be more different — one critical and epistemically austere, the other confidently revelatory — but the target is the same: a self that is genuinely the origin of its own acts, because it is not, in the relevant sense, the product of anything else.

III. Where They Pull Apart

The differences are at least as important as the resemblance, and they fall along three axes. Each is a place where the shared *shape* of perfection-as-trajectory is filled with incompatible content.

Epistemic posture: postulate versus revelation

Kant’s postulates — God, freedom, immortality — are explicitly *not* knowledge claims. They are what practical reason must assume for morality to be coherent, held with what Kant calls moral faith rather than theoretical certainty; the immortality on which endless progress depends is postulated, not proved⁹, and its acceptance is a need of pure practical reason, not an insight into a supersensible fact¹⁰. The whole critical project is built to block exactly the kind of confident metaphysical speculation about the soul, God, and eternity that would turn a postulate into a doctrine: the first *Critique* insists that “thoughts without content are empty, intuitions without concepts are blind”¹¹, and the bounds of sense it draws are precisely bounds on what the understanding may claim to *know* about the unconditioned.

Latter-day Saint theology occupies the opposite posture. It makes confident, revelation-based metaphysical claims about premortal existence, the structure of the afterlife, and the nature of godhood; the King Follett discourse advances them not as regulative assumptions but as disclosed facts¹², and the Book of Mormon frames the very reception of truth as a matter of revelation — “by the power of the Holy Ghost ye may know the truth of all things”¹³. This is not a difference of detail but of genre. Kant’s whole discipline is designed to forbid what the tradition takes itself licensed by revelation to affirm. The two are not competing theories at the same epistemic level; they are claims held under two different warrants, and the warrant is where the deepest divergence lies.

⁶Immanuel Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason*, trans. J. M. D. Meiklejohn (Public domain (Project Gutenberg), 1781), A538/B566.

⁷Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason*, A546/B574.

⁸Joseph Smith, “The King Follett Discourse,” 1844.

⁹Kant, *Critique of Practical Reason*, Ak. 5:122.

¹⁰Kant, *Critique of Practical Reason*, Ak. 5:126.

¹¹Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason*, A51/B75.

¹²Smith, “The King Follett Discourse”.

¹³*The Book of Mormon* (Palmyra, New York: E. B. Grandin, 1830), Moroni 10:5.

Asymptote versus arrival

For Kant, the finite rational being never actually *becomes* holy. It approaches holiness forever, and a qualitative gap between the creature and the holy will — which is to say, God — remains permanently in place; the endless progress is progress precisely because it never terminates¹⁴. The asymptote is the point: to close the gap would be to end the moral striving that, for Kant, constitutes the creature's dignity.

Eternal progression in Latter-day Saint thought is more radical. The doctrine of exaltation holds that humans can actually become gods themselves — a real future parity of kind, compactly stated in Lorenzo Snow's couplet that as man now is, God once was, and as God now is, man may become¹⁵, and grounded in the King Follett teaching that God himself was once as man now is¹⁶. Scripture is read in the same key: the Sermon's command to be perfect is repeated in the Book of Mormon as an attainable end — “be perfect even as I, or your Father who is in heaven is perfect”¹⁷ — and Moroni's closing exhortation promises a real completion: those who come to Christ are “perfected in him”¹⁸. That is a difference of degree becoming a difference of kind — indeed a collapse of the very gap Kant fixes permanently in place. Kant would almost certainly see the move as overstepping the limits of practical postulation into dogmatic metaphysics: the asymptote has been declared to arrive, and on the strength of a revelation his critical philosophy will not admit as knowledge.

The kind of God at the end

The third divergence concerns the terminus itself. Kant's God is a non-anthropomorphic postulate, needed to guarantee that virtue and the happiness proportioned to it eventually coincide — the highest good requires a moral author of the world¹⁹. This God is a moral world-governor, not a being a human could become; the postulate secures the coherence of the moral life without populating the supersensible with a describable person. The Latter-day Saint God is embodied, personal, and ontologically continuous with humanity, differing from the exalted human in degree of glory and knowledge rather than in kind of being²⁰ — the very continuity the Johannine promise that “we shall be like him, for we shall see him as he is”²¹ is read to underwrite. For Kant the process ends at a God categorically unlike its participants; for the tradition it ends at a God the participants have joined.

IV. A Compact Framing

If the resemblance and the rupture are to be held in one thought, it is this. Kant gives us an *epistemically modest, asymptotic* version of eternal progression: endless approach, never arrival, with no claim to know it is true — a trajectory reason must posit for the sake of morality, terminating in a God it may not describe. The Latter-day Saint tradition gives us an *epistemically confident, teleological* version: actual arrival, doctrinally asserted, with ontological continuity between the human and the divine — a trajectory revelation discloses, terminating in a God the traveler becomes.

¹⁴Kant, *Critique of Practical Reason*, Ak. 5:122.

¹⁵Lorenzo Snow, “The Grand Destiny of Man,” 1901.

¹⁶Smith, “The King Follett Discourse”.

¹⁷*The Book of Mormon*, 3 Nephi 12:48.

¹⁸*The Book of Mormon*, Moroni 10:32.

¹⁹Kant, *Critique of Practical Reason*, Ak. 5:124.

²⁰Smith, “The King Follett Discourse”.

²¹*The Holy Bible: World English Bible*, 1 John 3:2.

The family resemblance is genuine, and it is not superficial. Both refuse a single, instantaneous, static salvation-event; both make the self the kind of thing that is not wholly constituted from outside; both make perfection a matter of process rather than of sudden bestowal. A comparison that denied the resemblance would be as false as one that overstated it. But the two diverge sharply, and along the axes that matter most to each: on *how confidently* one is permitted to say that perfection is a process — a permission Kant restricts to moral faith and the tradition extends to revealed knowledge — and on *whether the gap* between creature and God ever actually closes, which Kant fixes open as the condition of moral striving and the tradition declares closed as the promise of exaltation.

What the comparison finally exposes is a trade each tradition makes. Kant purchases epistemic honesty at the cost of arrival: the price of never overclaiming about the supersensible is that the creature never crosses the gap, and holiness remains forever a standard rather than an attainment²². The tradition purchases arrival at the cost of epistemic modesty: the price of promising real deification is a confidence about premortal intelligence, embodied deity, and the structure of the afterlife that Kant's whole critical apparatus was built to forbid²³. Neither trade is obviously the wrong one. But they are different trades, and seeing that they are different — that the shared refusal of static salvation branches, almost immediately, into two incompatible economies of hope — is what the comparison is for.

V. Conclusion

The promise that whoever believes “should not perish, but have eternal life”²⁴ can be read in two registers, and the whole distance between Kant and eternal progression is the distance between them. Read as the gift of an *unending life* in which the moral vocation is pursued without term, it is Kant's: eternal life as the endless field across which the will approaches a holiness it never seizes, held as a hope reason may posit but not verify. Read as the promise of *becoming like* the one who gives it²⁵, it is the tradition's: eternal life as the medium of a real transformation whose terminus is participation in the divine nature itself.

Both readings honor the same refusal — that salvation is not a single static moment but a life-long, indeed eternal, ascent. Neither collapses into the other. The philosopher's asymptote and the prophet's arrival are not two names for one doctrine; they are two answers to a shared question, given under two warrants, and resolving into two Gods. To see them clearly is to see that the resemblance which first invited the comparison — perfection as trajectory — is the beginning of the inquiry and not its conclusion. Where the trajectory leads, and whether one may claim to know, is where Kant and the Saints part company; and it is there, not in the shared refusal that unites them, that each tradition says what is most its own.

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²²Kant, *Critique of Practical Reason*, Ak. 5:122.

²³Smith, “The King Follett Discourse”.

²⁴*The Holy Bible: World English Bible*, John 3:16.

²⁵*The Holy Bible: World English Bible*, 1 John 3:2.

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Index Locorum

*Every passage this essay engages, gathered under its source and sorted by reference. Generated by **inkhaven** **index-locorum** from the loci the prose actually cites; the movement in which each is cited follows it. Works cited whole — the King Follett discourse and Snow’s couplet — carry no locus and so do not appear here.*

Critique of Practical Reason @kant-cpracr

Ak. 5:32 II

Ak. 5:122 II–IV

Ak. 5:124 III

Ak. 5:126 III

Critique of Pure Reason @kant-cpr

A51/B75 III

A538/B566 II

A546/B574 II

The Book of Mormon @book-of-mormon

3 Nephi 12:48 III

Moroni 10:5 III

Moroni 10:32 III

The Holy Bible: World English Bible @bible

1 John 3:2 III, V

Isaiah 28:10 II

John 3:16 V

Matthew 5:48 II